

▷ EGG TOOTH

These day-old chicks still have the hard white egg tooth at the end of their beak, which they used to break out of their shell.



thick layer
of feathers
insulates body



Great gray owl

Strix nebulosa

▽ WINGED WONDER

A light body and broad wings allow slow, silent flight, and help the owl to maneuver with precision between trees. Special fringes on the wing feathers almost eliminate wing noise.

- ↔ 23–27 in (59–69 cm)
- 🏠 2–4 lb (0.8–1.7 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐭 Voles, mice, birds, frogs
- 🏠 



N. and C. North America,
E. Europe, Asia

This owl's thick insulation makes it look large, but its body is actually much smaller and lighter than the eagle owl or great horned owl. A less fearsome predator, the great gray owl focuses on small prey, often in difficult conditions. The disklike face, more than 20 in (50 cm) wide, suggests astonishingly acute hearing, although the owl's small eyes seem more suited to daylight than nighttime activity. Unusually for an owl, it hunts by day and at night. The facial feathers let sound through easily but protect what is hidden behind: an arc of stiff feathers that directs sound right into the asymmetrically positioned ears. This helps the owl to locate the source of a sound with pinpoint accuracy.

Great gray owls watch and listen for voles from a perch, often a broken tree stump, and glide down silently to catch them, taking them by surprise. They can hear tunneling rodents under layers of snow, and penetrate 16–20 in (40–50 cm), plunging headfirst, with a final thrust of their deadly feet. Found mainly in the north, a small population of great gray owls remains in the Sierra Nevada of California.

wide facial disk

broad,
fingered
wings

short,
broad tail

